9
PLAN TO UNLOCK

3 APRIL 2020

INDIA | 2,780 ACTIVE CASES | 87 DEATHS

WORLD | 9,02,387 ACTIVE CASES | 63,600 DEATHS

Times were grim. Tens of thousands of people had taken to the streets in an effort to return to their home towns. Every arm of the GoI was working in overdrive to provide comfort and necessities to these groups, in an effort to make them settle where they were, and halt their march. The prime minister had spoken over video call with the chief ministers just a day before, on 2 April, specifically asking them to ensure that the poor got food, shelter and clean drinking water. The machinery was overladen with fear and anxiety, what if these folks took the disease to the villages and hinterland? We could potentially witness mass annihilation like never seen before. The invisible enemy would consume our small towns and villages with a vengeance and in the absence of available treatment, there wouldn't be much we would be able to do. Businesses and companies were working from home and several had begun to experience cash crunch. The sentiment was at an all-time low. People were caged in their own homes, fearing that even the air they breathe could possibly be fatal. At this stage, the prime minister, donning his role as the consoler-in-chief, needed to come forth to offer strength and courage. In another effort to increase outreach regarding the virus and COVID-19-appropriate behaviour, especially among the rural folks, he appealed to the people, 'I want nine minutes from you all on 5 April, Sunday. Switch off all the lights in your homes, come to the door or the balcony and light a candle, diya or switch on the torchlight on your phones.'

He added, 'The collective power of unity of 1.3 billion of us will be felt through and this unity will give us the strength to pass these very difficult